Bergson

The greatest strength and weakness of French high culture in the last few centuries has been the close connection between philosophy and poetry. Henri Bergson, who won the Nobel Prize for Literature in 1927, was one of the great exemplars of this connection in French high culture. He was a great prose poet who generated philosophical ideas without constructing a system, while producing a critique of the contemporary status of knowledge and culture that demands answers. He may not answer all his questions, but they are important questions. What he thought he discerned in nature and in the world around us is something called *élan vital*, which we might describe as the life force, something that is the opposite of mere matter, a thing that has creativity, dynamism, if not direction, at least motion. It is not static but dynamic and it is the essence of all living things.

This is an anti-reductive or anti-naturalistic reading of Darwin. Organic nature develops, but something is expressed in that process which cannot be reduced to physicochemical elements. The *élan vital* can be understood metaphorically as the inverse of entropy: rather than the dissipation of available energy, it represents a drive toward greater complexity and a wider domain of activity. The *élan vital* is a skeleton key, a linking thread between human and nonhuman living activities, contrasted with dead, brute matter. Like so many in the French intellectual tradition, Bergson is a dualist. Dualisms, particularly Cartesian survivals, run through his philosophy. The *élan vital* can occupy the place of spirit in its distinction from matter. Matter and spirit form a major distinction in his work.

He tried to distinguish our scientific or objective or analytic knowledge of the external world from another kind of knowledge: that of immediate experience. Bergson is primarily concerned with the interiority of the self, with the direct apprehension of the external world prior to the point where we impose concepts, ideas, mathematical or scientific formulae on the world. He tries to remove the cellophane of conceptual interpretation that we impose on the world and mistake for the world itself, returning to the *Urstoff*, the substance of immediate personal and phenomenological experience.

A characteristic difficulty is that interiority is hard to express literally: these facts belong to individual experience rather than being publicly accessible. He's going to have a hard time making the jump from these internal subjective facts of interiority and subjectivity towards the external world. In referring to interiority, subjectivity and experience, he offers metaphors, images and analogies rather than literal speech. On the one hand we might say that that's the great defect of such a project. It doesn't lend itself to literal speech and it leaves us uncertain as to what exactly he's referring to. On the other hand if we take this project of prose poetry more seriously, since after all we do it with figures like Nietzsche, perhaps there's something to be learned from these metaphors, images and poetic references which can gesture at some other way of thinking about knowledge and human experience which will serve to inform and alter our understanding of the external world.

Bergson produced a wide variety of works over several decades, three or four of which became particularly influential. One important work, *An Introduction to Metaphysics*,

appeared as an essay in 1903. It contains a remarkable and memorable formulation. “Metaphysics is the science which claims to dispense with symbols.” At first, the meaning of this claim may be difficult to grasp. Rereading Bergson can make it more intelligible. Bergson has a great gift for formulating enigmatic, paradoxical, peculiar thoughts in a very poetic and attractive way. Bergson straddles the line between poetry and philosophy like so many of the great figures in French high culture and that's something to be borne in mind whenever we go back reading him. Don't ask for more precision, logical or linguistic, than this intellect can possibly offer you.

A second important work of his is called *Creative Evolution* which is an interpretation of the process of Darwinian evolution in a non-mechanistic, non-naturalistic way. What makes evolution creative is the fact that it contains *élan vital*, this anti-mechanical, anti-naturalistic, anti-entropic force which means that if evolution doesn't have a purpose, it at least has dynamism, motion. It's not quite as mechanical and blind and unseeing as Darwin would have suggested.

Two other works deserve attention. *Laughter* is arguably the finest philosophical treatment of comedy ever written and reveals the richness and depth of Bergson's outlook. Few thinkers concern themselves with such varied subjects. Comedy is a particularly difficult genre to write about. It resists facile generalizations. Since Aristotle's foundational treatment of comedy has not survived, and the surviving *Poetics* primarily concerns tragedy, our connection with classical comic theory is limited. Bergson's contribution is therefore especially important. His book appeared in 1900. Its ideas can be illustrated by later figures such as Charlie Chaplin as well as by the older tradition of Aristophanes. Another of Bergson's major books is *The Two Sources of Morality and Religion*. Here he distinguishes intuitive from analytical approaches to religion and morals.

One leads to dead, stultifying, static morality and religion; the other leads to something open and creative. For Bergson, these terms express approval and praise. He approves of open religion and creative morality, offering reasons, or at least metaphors and images, that invite inquiry even when they do not persuade. Logical persuasion may not be his strength, but poetic images can do both more and less than logical persuasion.

The influences on Bergson help place this project in context. His work can be read as an homage to Heraclitus. He was the pre-Socratic philosopher of change and becoming, for whom all is flux. Bergson is someone who's interested not in the static but in the dynamic, not in the fixed but in the changeable and in some respects his whole philosophy is homage to becoming. Plotinus, a founder of Neoplatonism, brought together mystical elements of Platonism in a synthesis that later influenced Christianity. Bergson has often been compared with him because of his tendency to move from obscurity into myth and to unite eclectic intellectual elements, not primarily through logical coherence but because they give his outlook a certain wholeness. As Plotinus is often described as a mystic with great respect for reasoning, something similar can be said of Bergson.

Bergson, not surprisingly, has great respect for mysticism. Another source would be Descartes because of the foundational certainty of the self. The self is the starting point for many of the great French philosophies. This is true of both Descartes and Bergson.

In addition, Darwin is very important because this idea of evolution takes as its presupposition the idea of organic Darwinian evolution within nature. What he adds to Darwin is the idea of openness. There is no natural mechanism behind it. It has an entelechy but it is an entelechy which doesn't achieve any final telos. In some ways, like Gadamer, he's looking for something less general and less complete than Hegel's giant system where we go to the end of history and yet doesn't want to succumb to a completely pointless, to a completely random interpretation of history.

He wants something in between. He wants to hold on to the idea of organic evolution but he wants to keep the idea of human creativity as adding something necessary and unavoidable to that process. Readers familiar with William James and the stream of consciousness will feel at home with Bergson. Bergson and James knew each other and admired each other's work. Whitehead offers another comparison: process connects religion and science. Undoing the fixed character of the world and of the language referring to it is important both for Whitehead's conception of process and for Bergson's.

One stimulus to Bergson's questioning of science is the feeling that it fails to remain faithful to human experience. He went back to the pre-Socratics, particularly to Zeno and his paradoxes, in order to show that our scientific conceptions of space and time are inadequate and do not live up to our actual experience of space and time. Our internal experience of space and time differs from their scientific description.

Consider Zeno's paradox of the arrow. At each instant in the flight of an arrow it is occupying a space exactly the size of the arrow. At none of these instants can it occupy a space larger than its size, so there is no instant at which it can change location. Zeno draws the inference that motion is impossible. Calculus and the idea of continuity resolve some of these problems of instantaneous motion. Bergson does something else with it. He argues that our experiences of space and time are fundamentally different, challenging the treatment of them as a single continuum common in scientific descriptions.

Space and time are not merely given or abstract. They are lived experiences, and when we examine not what science tells us space and time are, but when we experience space and time directly and in an unmediated way, we will find that the way science handles space and time falsifies the reality of it, and this will serve to ground our movement away from science towards immediate phenomenological apprehension. This leads to his conception of time.

For Bergson, time is heterogeneous, whereas space is homogeneous. Lived time contains different kinds of moments, unlike clock time. For Bergson, scientific conceptions of time rely on spatialized metaphors treated literally. If a stopwatch is started, how do we know when ten minutes have passed? The hand has crossed a particular portion of the dial. We judge time by the movement of something through space. Yet Bergson insists that space and time differ, and that science is pervaded by spatial metaphors, particularly the spatialization of time. We think of points in time. We think of a timeline, and Bergson's point is that that's not what time is, and that we need these metaphors in order to make science work, but time doesn't break up into little

homogeneous units the way space does. Bergson calls time as we experience it *durée*, and he says this experience of time is very different from clock time.

He expresses this enigmatically and poetically, in a way reminiscent of Proust: *durée* is the experience of waiting for sugar to dissolve in a drink. It's one thing to just take out a stopwatch and watch the hand go around, but while that may be happening simultaneously with the duration of my tea getting its sugar, the point is that one is describing time and experience of the world from the inside, the other from the outside. One is talking about the direct apprehension of temporality, the other based upon a metaphor, a spatial metaphor for what temporality is. Bergson proposes returning to direct experience and temporarily bracketing science. Science remains available for practical uses, but space and time, and their modes of experience, are distinct. When we try and treat space and time as a continuous whole, we end up with the paradoxes of Zeno.

He seeks to escape Zeno's paradoxes by challenging the treatment of space and lived time as a single continuum and emphasizing their fundamental difference. All objects in the world are connected in time, but they're separated in space. Time is heterogeneous, whereas space is homogeneous. Time is irreversible, space is reversible. Time is irreplaceable, space is replaceable. Time is unique, space is not unique. Time is dynamic; space is static. Bergson creates a series of dualisms corresponding to this distinction. He challenges the treatment of lived time as a spatial continuum, reformulating our description of experience and using it to assess other intellectual approaches. A comparison can be drawn with Heidegger's temporality of Dasein, understood as the way human beings directly experience time. *durée* is not the spatialized time of clocks; it can also be compared with Husserl's account of lived time.

Husserl wrote a whole book called *The Phenomenology of Internal Time Consciousness*, the point being that internal time, the way we experience it, and external time, spatialized through metaphors, are fundamentally different. A corresponding series of dualisms runs through his philosophy: mind and matter, accident and essence, science and metaphysics, space and time, body and soul, matter and memory, analysis and intuition, intelligence and instinct. The split between the internal and external worlds is never fully overcome in Bergson.

This division makes his critique of science possible. A central distinction is that between analysis and intuition. Intuition can be subjective, nebulous and difficult to articulate. A comparison can be made with R. G. Collingwood, who distinguishes the inside of an event from its outside: the agent's perspective from that of an external observer. Adopting the agent's perspective changes our way of looking and draws on a common human capacity for empathy or intuitive understanding. Bergson is suggesting that intuition does something like that. It's something we all have in common. It is elemental and prior to analysis.

Analysis moves objectively around its object and investigates it from outside. Measurement requires instruments such as clocks and spatial metaphors treated literally. These impose concepts on the external world: pragmatic fictions useful for manipulating it, but not representations of direct experience. The way we experience the world directly is called intuition, and in contrast to analysis, which moves around its

object and is relative, intuition enters into its object and is absolute. This recalls Collingwood's distinction.

Intuition matters because it enters an object without the mediation of symbols. Fifteen or twenty minutes can be experienced directly, without consulting a clock and inferring elapsed time from the position of its hands. Intuition is this direct apprehension. Bergson criticizes earlier metaphysics for continuing intellectual homogenization and analysis instead of returning to primal experience. Kant's a priori categories, Democritus's atoms and Descartes's clear and distinct ideas all attempt to perform analysis within the domain of intuition. They are trying to make metaphysics mediated by concepts, and the point is these concepts all adhere to the external world, not to the internal world. Concepts have to do with objectively analyzing the world. They are not part of *durée*, or they are not part of intuition.

Intuition directly apprehends the world without the use of words or symbols, so that's what he meant at the beginning of his essay *An Introduction to Metaphysics* when he says that metaphysics is the science that claims to dispense with symbols. He says that metaphysics is the science of the things that we directly apprehend. It's the science of intuition, or more precisely, it is human experience. It precedes our constructions of the physical world; in that sense, metaphysics precedes physics, and intuition precedes analysis. Yet intuition remains a nebulous concept. Prose poets have the characteristic difficulty of being hard to pin down: their literal meaning is often uncertain.

Bergson is at his best in his suggestive examples, even when his metaphysics is hazy. The first is visiting Paris. It's a wonderful city. To go to Paris is a fundamentally different experience from being shown all the possible photographs of Paris from every possible perspective. Suppose I give you a tremendous stack of photos of Paris. If you think of those photos as representing Paris as it is indicated by concepts, they become flat and two-dimensional and square. They are forced into a procrustean mold which does not do justice to the living reality of Paris. What Bergson will say is that intuition is what happens to you when you go to Paris and experience Paris. Images and representations can analyze elements of Paris, such as its architecture or street plan. Yet no collection of images, however large, can replace the immediate experience of visiting the city. Receiving many postcards from someone's holiday does not mean taking that holiday oneself.

These are fundamentally different experiences. A second example of intuition is the self. I have a direct intuition of my own existence, of my own consciousness, and I don't need to have symbols mediate that for me. I do not need to ask anyone: “Do I exist? Am I a self?” I apprehend this directly. Compare that to the analytic parsing of the self that we get in various psychoanalytic theories. Maybe I have an id. Maybe I don't. Maybe I have a superego. Maybe I don't. But the whole set of parsings, the whole set of concepts which one would hope, in a general theory of the psyche, would account for the various modes of human activity, moods, feelings, sentiments, all that, all of those theoretical constructs cannot replace the direct intuition of being me or being you. You intuit that directly. There is always some discrepancy between our conceptual analytic representation of anything and our direct intuitive apprehension of that thing, provided it is something that can be apprehended intuitively. Not everything can be done that way, but some things are like that.

A third example is the hero of a novel. Reading Goethe's *The Sorrows of Young Werther* and discovering what Werther is like differs from being told about the novel. An account might use concepts such as protagonist or antagonist. It might discuss the genre, Werther's dispositions, mental states and behavior. None of those descriptions of Werther will be like your direct apprehension of what Werther is like when you experience that work of art. It seems then there are certain things which are not done justice when we try and describe them using analytic concepts, using our rationality. It's hard to know how to evaluate such a claim because it seems to have elements of truth and also very dubious elements built into it too.

The problem with Bergson is that he oftentimes doesn't bother to give us a formal logical argument. He's a prose poet, to be compared with someone like Nietzsche, for example, who gives you interesting ideas to think about, and then you don't quite know how to evaluate them. When he's talking about instinct, he says that instinct is to intelligence or analysis as vision is to touch. Instinct, in this analogy, tells us about things at a distance. Reasoning then approaches and makes them more tangible. But how can the supposed superiority of intuition over analysis and reasoning be established? That remains uncertain. One way to understand the project is that Bergson's poetic outlook and his awareness of difficulties in modern scientific society lead him to formulate a philosophical alternative.

It centers on creativity, subjectivity, interiority and the *élan vital*. To think intuitively is to think in duration, yet no image or concept is identical with duration. Nevertheless, *durée* must itself be communicated through a concept, and nothing seems quite capable of conveying it. Bergson leaves us with poetic paradoxes: no concept adequately expresses duration, but how else can he tell us about it? He emphasizes subjectivity but must make concessions to the objective world in order to communicate. He moves into metaphorical and poetic language, yet is still obliged to use language and analysis at least some of the time.

Another important work revealing his optimistic and poetic tendencies is *The Two Sources of Morality and Religion*. Here he argues for the *élan vital*, the reality of moral sentiments and the intellectual seriousness of religion. The *élan vital* works through history without being mechanical or purely naturalistic. It's something like Geist, in Hegel's sense, but without the telos, without the eschaton, the end of history, and it's also something like Darwin's conception of nature, of natural evolution, natural selection, but it's not mechanical, it's not blind, and it allows for real novelty and creativity. Oftentimes, it seems that what Bergson is trying to do is have his cake and eat it too. It seems like he's very impressed with Darwinian naturalism, and he's very impressed with the theory of evolution, feels that the human condition has been fundamentally changed by the advent of Darwinism.

Yet he also wants to preserve what naturalism threatens. He rejects complete reunion with nature if its price is eliminating freedom, novelty and the interiority that makes us human. He constructs this second way of looking at evolution as being creative rather than mechanical, at least potentially, and argues that this establishes the special qualities of human existence as opposed to the existence of other animals which may fit into that Darwinian model.

The first source of morality and religion is the external world, nature. We analyze it to obtain what we need, generating static religion: ancient myths and behavioral codes constructed as responses to human misery. In other words, a sociobiological or naturalistic interpretation of religion would say that people are terrified by the world. It's full of pain, and misery, and anxiety, and problems. Bergson roots archaic, static religion in human needs interacting with nature. Its accounts of nature may not be sophisticated or persuasive, but they maintain social cohesion, support the survival of the species and integrate society.

Corresponding to this static religion, Bergson thinks of something called closed morality. Closed morality is that system of imperatives, that system of moral rules, which is connected to static religion and which derives from the same source as static religion, the simple need for human community, which requires laws, which requires regulation, which requires analysis and rigidity for its effectiveness to become manifest. There's a second source of morality in religion, and this is Bergson's big contribution, or at least this is what he thinks his big contribution is. He says that in addition to the static religion and the closed morality of ancient societies, where people were just pulling themselves out of the domain of nature, there's a second alternative, which we get not through analysis, but through intuition, and not through natural selection, but through *élan vital*. The alternative to static religion is what he calls dynamic religion, and the alternative to closed morality is what he calls open morality. Dynamic religion and open morality both have their source in intuition.

Here Bergson affirms mysticism. He says that within dynamic religion, and this is true not just within the Western tradition of religion, but in all the world's religions, that all the great mystics are something like spiritual pioneers who break through the old, static, stultifying forms of religion towards some new, higher and finer intuition. His idea of the great mystics who broke through the established bounds of religion are people like St. Paul, St. Francis. Mysticism can lead beyond religion as a heteronomous activity, in Kant's sense, toward autonomy. Unlike Kant, Bergson finds the source of autonomous religion and morality in intuition rather than reasoning. It will be in our direct, pre-linguistic apprehension of the world. In other words, we see right and wrong. Some of us apparently have a more direct apprehension of that and can instruct the others. When this instruction becomes social, religion moves from being static to dynamic. Morality moves from being closed, a rigid set of systems, to an open set that at least allows for a greater domain of human freedom.

This is always a product of intuition, never of analytical activity. After such large claims, one might expect a careful historical argument: actual people and places, dates and events demonstrating the transformation. Bergson gives few such details. Specifics are not his strength. He seeks, if not to revive religion and morality through direct personal intuition, at least to legitimize them or prevent twentieth-century thought from leaving them behind.

His writing on comedy belongs to this optimistic project, unique in twentieth-century thought. However dubious, nebulous or questionable his treatment of morality, religion and knowledge may be, his writings on comedy are arguably the best things ever written on the genre. It's a very difficult topic. Bergson attempts to articulate conditions for the comic. He connects laughter with intelligence. For him, laughter belongs

specifically to the human domain. A dog does not understand a joke told to it. He associates this with human intelligence. Another attractive feature of his account is the claim that laughter and comedy serve a moral function. That's why society invented them. Also that's why they're universal. Amazingly enough, there's no society that hasn't invented the joke.

This suggests something common beneath our different cultural experiences. The contrast between tragedy and comedy is revealing. Tragedy individuates. When Hamlet dies at the end of *Hamlet*, his death is tied to his particular tragic flaws. On one reading, these include Oedipal feelings toward his mother, indecision and excessive reflection. Hamlet is specifically Hamlet. Tragedy generally ends in death. Death always individuates, pulls the tragic hero away from society, makes the tragic hero separate, makes him an epitome of his sins and offers him the appropriate agony for his sins or his transgressions, his flaws. Tragedy is about individuals. Retitling *Hamlet* “The Indecisive Oedipal Guy” would itself produce a comic response. It is funny because the play concerns Hamlet, not merely a type of indecisive Oedipal man.

Think of Othello. Othello is Othello, a great heroic man who's destroyed by his own jealousy. We could not simply retitle *Othello* “The Story of the Jealous Guy,” because the play is about Othello. It is not about a type of a person. It is not about a characteristic moral deformity. It is about Othello's moral deformity. It is about Hamlet's moral deformity. It is about King Lear's moral deformity. Each tragedy concerns a specific quality of its central figure. Tragic heroes are individuals. Here Bergson's argument is especially perceptive.

Comedy works in the opposite direction. Comedy does not end in death. On the whole, comedy ends in marriage. Perhaps sex and death are the two poles of human life, and I would be inclined to say that marriage is symbolic sex. When the comic hero marries at the end, he is reintegrated into society. Instead of being killed off and individuated, exactly the opposite happens. He gets collectivized. He gets thrown back into the mix so that he can have sex and then produce more little comic heroes, and they can get thrown back into the mix. Comedy gestures at collectivity. Tragedy gestures at individuality.

It's a deep argument. It goes even further. He further argues that comedy is not about individual people. Comedy is always about kinds or types of people. Consider Molière's *The Miser*. Not Joe, the miserly man. Rather, the miser is a type of person. Consider *The Misanthrope*. We're not talking about someone that doesn't like other people. We're talking about misanthropy in general. Comedy refers to types, to generalities. It doesn't refer to specific individuals, which is connected to the way comedy and tragedy finish up and their function in society. Comedy thus concerns generalities. It is morally instructive and didactic. The point of the miser is to hold miserliness or stinginess up to ridicule by making it appear as foolish as it in fact is. It is morally didactic as well.

Bergson also examines the structure of comic action. He does not merely describe comedy from the outside or compare it with tragedy. He asks what makes a familiar incident, such as slipping on a banana peel, comic. Someone walking down the street slips on a banana peel and lands on the ground. People laugh, at least sometimes. Why is it funny? One condition is that no one seems seriously hurt. If the person falls and

breaks a leg, the incident ceases to be funny. Then pity takes over. The comic response requires a temporary suspension of sympathy; we do not want real harm to come to someone who is, after all, like us.

The fall is funny because a human being, spirit or *élan vital*, forgets itself and behaves like matter. Bergson finds the comic in mechanical rigidity imposed on living activity. Someone falling appears to act like a mere object, like a piece of wood. Comedy concerns people acting like objects. He also proposes structural rules for comedy, beginning with repetition.

A later illustration is Abbott and Costello's routine *Who's on First?*: “Who” is on first, “What” is on second, and “I Don't Know” is on third. The dialogue repeats endlessly. The frustration of the person who fails to understand is amusing because he does not catch on and behaves like wood or a dummy. It is as if one were speaking to a wall. The words are repeated, but communication does not occur. The repetition is key to comedy. A second structural element in comedy, according to Bergson, is inversion. This is the inversion of roles.

A later film example is the scene in *Raiders of the Lost Ark* where a swordsman confronts Indiana Jones, waving his weapon threateningly. The situation appears dangerous for Indiana, who simply draws his gun and shoots him. For a moment, Indiana Jones is the prey; then he becomes the predator. That's funny because it's an inversion of roles. Bergson is really on to something here.

A third structural principle is the reciprocal interference of independent series of events. A mistaken connection is made between two unrelated series, and ambiguity leads to misinterpretation. In Oscar Wilde's *The Importance of Being Earnest*, people talk past each other. Different series of events interfere and are misunderstood by people who do not know what is happening. That's going to be important in the structural rules of comedy as well. Beyond this, Bergson also analyzes verbal comedy. He says that there's verbal comedy within language and then just merely expressed in language.

Humor inherent in language is often difficult to translate. One example is the old joke: “Take my wife, please.” Its effect depends on the ambiguity between introducing one's wife as an example and asking someone to take her away. Translating it into another language, such as Arabic, may not preserve the effect. It is an old and rather feeble joke, but it depends on the language itself. This is one kind of verbal comedy. Another is merely expressed in language and is, in principle, translatable.

One example is the literal interpretation of metaphors, which is comic because a metaphor is not meant literally. This effect can be translated. Such literal readings cause comic misunderstanding and incoherence. Meanings can also be transposed. *The Importance of Being Earnest* plays on “Ernest,” a man's name, and “earnest,” meaning serious or sincere. Moving between these meanings produces comic effects, as Wilde demonstrates. Bergson also distinguishes comic remarks from witty remarks.

With a comic remark, one laughs at the speaker. When somebody says something that's witty, you're either laughing at a third person or you're laughing at yourself. He offers an elaborate taxonomy of comic effects. It does not replace Aristotle, but it is an

exceptionally rich, almost encyclopedic treatment. Readers studying philosophy for enjoyment are likely to find *Laughter* rewarding. It can be funny as well as illuminating. Overall, the comic is the side of a person that reveals a resemblance to a thing.

Slipping on a banana peel resembles the fall of an inanimate object, such as a lectern. The person is turned into an object, and this reduction produces the comic experience. The imperfection of human beings, their ability to forget themselves, their ability to forget what they are, demands a social corrective. This social corrective is called comedy. In other words, we laugh at people to remind them that they're souls rather than bodies.

A similar justification was offered for English Restoration comedy. Puritans regarded comedy as immoral and a source of depravity. Its defenders replied that it had a morally instructive purpose: exposing vice to ridicule and improving the spectator. Bergson's argument for comedy runs more or less along those lines. He says that what it holds up is human deformity, our tendency to slip back into nature, slip back into the world of the object, slip back into the world of matter. Laughter reminds us that we should not do this, because that is not what we are.

Society reminds us that we are souls rather than mere bodies. The variety of Bergson's subjects, the subtlety and poetry but also the haziness of his ideas, and the metaphorical or aesthetic character of his writing can tempt us to dismiss him. Yet that would throw the baby out with the bathwater. We would lose the insights he offers in his strongest domain, aesthetics. Bergson is a deeply poetic figure. Bergson has a great subtlety of mind. Rationality or reasoning may not be his strong point, but he is able to discern things underlying, for example, the structure of comedy, which most of us would have had a real hard time with. His strengths are his aesthetic treatments, his occasionally very insightful and very thought-provoking metaphors, and his weak point is the fact that he never provides us with the argument that would make us convinced or feel some certainty or some surety that the argument he's making about the distinction between static and dynamic religion or open and closed morality really had any more validity than Bergson's wishful thinking.

Bergson thus occupies a unique position in twentieth-century thought. He's optimistic for the most part rather than pessimistic. He is respectful of science without being worshipful towards science, and he brings together the strongest and weakest points of French high culture in the 20th century, its tendency to undo the distinction between poetry and philosophy, which leads us to persuasive images and powerful metaphors, if not logical certainty and apodictic truth.